CHAPTER 18

L A B O R O R G A N I Z A T I O N A N D E N T E R P R I S E

In some important respects, the institutional framework of Palestine's economic development, particularly that of the Jewish community, has been unique. To our knowledge, Jewish Palestine provides a singular example of a labor organization assuming a primary role in a colonizing effort.

EARLY BEGINNINGS

The origin of this workers' movement can be traced to the character of the Jewish immigrants to Palestine at the turn of the present century (the second "Aliyah") and the economic conditions with which they were confronted. This wave of immigration had its inception in the pogroms of Kishenev and Homel in 1903 and in the collapse of the Russian Revolution of 1905. The failure to achieve social democratic reforms in Eastern Europe created a feeling of frustration among the Jewish youth and fostered the conviction that pogroms would remain the order of the day. Under the circumstances there were several tens of thousands ready to strike new roots in the old-new land of Palestine, especially the members of the "Poale Zion" (Labor Zionist) groups, who risked their lives in the Jewish self-defense during the Homel pogrom. This party, which is an international organization, regards a socialist Palestine as the radical solution of the Jewish problem.

By virtue of their socialist ideology, the Labor Zionists have been opposed to "exploitation" of labor and committed to the idea of self-labor. This attitude was erected into a creed by A. D. Gordon who in 1906 founded in Palestine another labor organization, Hapoel Hatzair (Young Workers) which places more emphasis on Zionism and rejects certain socialist principles that seem contrary to the Zionist objective. The "religion of labor" not only conforms to socialist concept of non-exploitation but is also uniquely suited to the needs of those Jews from the Diaspora who are attempting to reconstitute their National Home.